THE OBC GAMEPLAN

belonging to this caste. To boost the community's confidence, Modi's cabinet now has 27 ministers who are OBCs (of the total 78); many of the state unit chiefs are also from these caste cohorts.

The OBC focus started back in 2018 with constitutional status being granted to the National Commission for Backward Classes (NCBC), itself a result of the realisation in the BJP that the community had played a pivotal role in the Uttar Pradesh assembly election win the previous year. Article 338-B, inserted into the 102nd Amendment Act, also clarified that states had the right to make their own list of OBCs. It has opened up a window for the states to do their own respective caste-based surveys, which several leaders in the BJP and RSS believe is the way out than getting caught in the middle of the reservations quota tangle. Yet, the BJP is moving cautiously. Former Union minister Hansraj Ahir is now the chairman of NCBC, which monitors the implementation of OBC reservation in education and government jobs.

The party's OBC Morcha chief and Rajya Sabha member K. Laxman explained that the party will be looking to "expose the opposition" on how it had "betrayed the backward classes", going back into history with India's first prime minister Jawaharlal Nehru "dumping" the 1955 Kaka Kalelkar Commission report and, similarly, Indira Gandhi and Rajiv Gandhi ignoring the Mandal Commission recommendations. In essence, the party narrative is that the Nehru-Gandhi family stood in the way of social justice for OBCs, and PM Modi has come as their messiah.

This, of course, flies in the face of the BJP's own image—till about a decade ago—of being an anti-reservation Brahmin-Baniya outfit. It's the work done after 2014 by the party organisation and government policies that have helped allay fears and developed the OBC and Dalit communities as new voter bases. According to party estimates, in the 2024 general election, the community's vote will be crucial not just in the cow belt of UP, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Bihar and Chhattisgarh but even outside it in states like Odisha, Telangana and Karnataka.

What the Modi regime has done since 2014

- Brought in a constitutional amendment to give teeth to the National Commission for Backward Classes (NCBC)
- Given representation to the community, 27 OBC ministers now in the Union cabinet
- Social sector schemes delivered 'without discrimination'
- Extended reservation benefits to OBCs among Muslims and Christians
- States can now make their own OBC list to extend scheme benefits
- Legislation to ensure reservations for EWS over and above SC ceiling of 50 per cent

COMPLICATING MATTERS FOR THE BJP, OPPOSITION-RULED STATES WITH BIG OBC POPULATIONS SUCH AS ODISHA AND BIHAR HAVE INITIATED THEIR OWN CASTE SURVEYS

On March 29, the party held a conclave attended by 80-odd party MPs from the OBC community to get its action plan in place. By then, the BJP media cell had already got the wheels churning over Rahul's "attack on OBCs", and how the Surat court verdict vindicated their stand that PM Modi and all his caste brethren had been insulted (Rahul got bail on April 3, but the conviction stays for now). The challenge for the party, though, is that despite their claims for sympathies, the surname Modi doesn't denote an OBC community across states. The NCBC also doesn't have the community listed as OBC. The list for Gujarat shows Ghanchi (Muslim), Teli, Modh Ghanchi, Teli-Sahu, Teli-Rathod, Teli-Rathore as OBC communities. PM Modi belongs to the Modh-Ghanchi caste, so he lists himself as an OBC. Otherwise, the Modi surname is used by several communities, such as the Vaniks (Banias), Brahmins, Ghanchis and other sub-communities who find their origin in Gujarat's Modhera. The surname is widespread across castes in Punjab, Haryana, Bihar, UP, MP and Rajasthan as well.

The Congress, too, has tried to disrupt the BJP narrative. Congress leader and MP Shashi Tharoor remarked that at least two of the Modis Rahul called thieves in his comment, cricket administrator Lalit Modi and diamantaire Nirav Modi, "aren't OBCs...they are rich fat cats". The BJP, though, isn't ready to let go of this bone they have been presented with, and will be worrying it for at least some more time. The party think-tanks believe the 'politics of insults' cuts deep with the OBC community.

But the biggest challenge is the BJP's silence on having a national survey or caste census. The last full caste census happened way back in 1931. Since Independence, India has done a caste headcount just once, through the Socio-Economic Caste Census (SECC) in 2011. But the BJP-led NDA government rejected the report in 2015. The full data of the SECC findings was also never made public. A top government official said on condition of anonymity that the data listed over 3.5 million castes.

Complicating matters for the BJP, Opposition-ruled states with a dominant OBC population such as Odisha and Bihar have initiated their own caste surveys. Naveen Patnaik's Biju Janata Dal government in Odisha has moved to include 22 castes in the state's OBC list. It will also conduct an OBC survey this month. In Bihar, the Nitish Kumar-led government has already completed the survey, the results of which will be published in May, say officials. Some other states have also gone down this road, but pulled back after seeing danger signs ahead. In 2015, the Siddaramaiah-led Congress government in Karnataka had commissioned a Socio-Economic and Education Survey, but the results have not been released. So too the survey Tamil Nadu initiated in 2020 following pro-